INT. DAVID'S APARTMENT - AFTERNOON

The room is dim. A single cigarette butt smolders in a glass tray, sending up a thin ribbon of white smoke. The place is a wreck.

DAVID (40s), looks haggard, his eyes bloodshot. He is frantically tearing apart the sofa cushions. He pulls out two dusty quarters. He stares at them with pure, hollow despair.

Scattered on the floor are various "Past Due" notices and loan shark tallies. His phone vibrates on the coffee table.

MARCUS: *10PM tonight, not a single cent short.*

David collapses onto the floor, defeated. His foot accidentally strikes a canvas backpack. It topples over, spilling schoolbooks across the rug.

David sighs, kneeling to gather the mess. As he slides a textbook back in, a pink tin box slides out from a hidden sleeve. David hesitates. He slowly pries the lid open.

Inside is a thick wad of crumpled bills- fives, tens, twenties.

On top sits a folded piece of paper. In shaky, child-like handwriting: *"Daddy's Birthday Surprise. Only $40 more for the new suit!"*

David's hands begin to tremble. He counts it with feverish speed.

It's all there. Exactly the amount he needs when added to the change in his pocket.

The sound of a key turning in the lock. LILY (10) is home.

David snaps the lid shut, shoves the tin back into the bag, and zips it. A flicker of agonizing conflict flashes across his face.

LILY
Daddy? I'm home!

DAVID
Hey, bug. You're early.

Lily looks at the messy floor.

LILY
What are you doing on the floor?

DAVID
Just hunting for some spare change.
This sofa is a black hole.

Lily drops her coat. She studies his face with that unnerving clarity children have.

LILY
You're not sad about your birthday,
right?

DAVID
Birthdays are for kids.

LILY
That's not true. You cried last year.

David stiffens. He avoids her eyes, adjusting a cushion.

DAVID
That was allergies.

Lily gives him a skeptical look.

LILY
I'm gonna make this one better.

EXT. ABANDONED REPAIR SHOP

Driving rain. A black SUV idles. MARCUS (35) sits on the hood. He taps a baseball bat against his palm.

David enters the circle of light. His hand is buried in his heavy pocket.

MARCUS
You are three minutes late.

David keeps his head down, lips drawn tight. He pulses for a while.

DAVID
I have the money. It's all here.

He pulls out the wad of crumpled cash. An Ultraman sticker is stuck to a twenty-dollar bill.

MARCUS
You play games?

Marcus reaches for the money, but David suddenly jerks his hand back.

MARCUS (CONT'D)
David, I don't care if you rolled an old lady or cracked a piggy bank. Money is money. Hand it over.

David stares at the sticker. He looks up at Marcus.

DAVID
I'm not paying you.

MARCUS
What?

David stuffing the money back in, zips the pocket.

DAVID
This isn't for you. I owe you. I'll work, I'll pick up trash, I'll do whatever it takes. But this money is clean. It's not going into your pocket.

Marcus's smile vanishes.

MARCUS
Then I guess I have to teach you what "clean" actually means.

EXT. ABANDONED REPAIR SHOP - LATER

THUD! Marcus's fist sinks into David's gut. David hits the mud. Marcus begins kicking his ribs.

MARCUS
I'll give you one last chance. Hand it over!

David curls into a ball, shielding his pocket with both arms. He is silent, taking the blows. Every strike makes him squeeze the pocket tighter.

MARCUS (CONT'D)
Is it worth getting killed over some
(MORE)

MARCUS (CONT'D)
pocket change?

David forces a pained, bloody grin.

DAVID
You wouldn't understand.

Marcus looks at David's eyes, the look of a man who has finally found something worth more than his life. Disgusted, Marcus stops.

MARCUS
Psycho. I'll come for the furniture tomorrow.

The SUV roars away. David lies in the rain, gasping, his hand still buried in his pocket, clutching the money.

INT. LILY'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

David limps into the darkened apartment. He creeps into Lily's room. She is sound asleep.

He sits on the edge of the bed, wincing. He gently brushes her hair, a faint smile breaking through his bruised face.

Trembling, he slides the pink tin back into her backpack. He leans down and kisses her forehead.

DAVID
I'm sorry, babe. Daddy almost lost it.

INT. POLICE STATION - MORNING

The sky is a bright, brilliant blue. David sits on a chair inside the station, leaning on the white wall. His eye is swollen shut, clothes caked in mud.

An OFFICER (42) steps out. He stops, seeing David.

OFFICER
Sir? Do you need help?

David stands up. He sways, but his eyes are steady.

DAVID
I'd like to report a case of illegal lending and assault. My name is David Bennett... I'm a gambler. But I'm trying to be a father again.

FADE TO BLACK.